

Matador

Pupils scream tighter around the world. Sclerae vary: some whiten, some redden. Irises, gold flake for many. Corneae, stay the same. These changes—tightening, whitening, reddening, flaking, staying the same—are not noticed. Not until later. People, for the most part, are not worried about their eyes on droughtexit. Most are more far more preoccupied with sudden changes: personalities different, character different, morals different. A change in them, but from where? No recollection of where the change came from, but how?

Francois, and others like him, experienced droughexit differently. There was no blank space in memory for him, no. And there wasn't any joining with the others who remembered like him either. He woke as normal. Hinging at the waist and sitting up in bed, with recall of what happened as if from daily life. Make no mistake, it was still uncanny for him, but the serenity of it overshadowed everything else.

He sat there this time lingering in a memory, a fragment from this last drought. His mother was trying to help him, drive him to a hospital. To get help. She drove from another city 2.5 hours away to try to help. And she did it during the drought. How she knew to come, he didn't know. But there she was, at his door. He was 28 and she in the latter half of her 50s. He stood there, confused and riled up at her condescension. How could she show up like this, swoop in on him *presuming* to be able to “help”? He was fine, too. He'd cried out, yelped, a few hours prior, but it wasn't a yelp of pain. A part of his life, at the time of the yelp, had clicked. He'd realized that his childhood—every bit of it—had led to that moment. That moment of realizing that everything had led to that moment. Full circle.

There was more to the circle than that, however. On feeling this realization, on encountering it, bits and bobs within his life started to have things to say. They started ringing out, like tiny bells in his mind. Saying, “Remember this? You are here now and thinking of this and you are who you are because of it” or the times when his friends were rough on him in ways he didn't understand. He remembered them quoting a show, stating in mechanical reverie that they were facilitating. “The fuck are *you two* facilitating,” he'd always wondered. As if a coconut had fallen and knocked revelation into him, he realized it: they were facilitating the moment, the sculpting, the creation of themselves and Francois. Who they would go on to be, and who he would go on to become. He wondered where they were. Realized he hadn't spoken to them in years. Yelped. Screamed. Clogged his nose from the crying. In his crying, the bells kept ringing. Resounding and poking at him, like kodama in the forest of his life or the little flecks of sand and glitter that would infiltrate his heart after the beach bonfires he and his current friends enjoyed so much.—The mechanical action of the world always felt like the “element” he liked the most at those bonfires on the beach. He didn't identify with the fire or the water or the wind. For him, it was always the implicit brokenness of the sand that both irritated and enamored him.—“The

glitter and sand in his heart,” he thought. Those impurities would be the death of him, trigger a PAC or PVC and then off with some lethal arrhythmia. It wasn’t reasonable to think that way, but he stood there, crying in his apartment and tried to will a premature ventricular contraction. A premature anything. *Something* to topple the first domino so he wouldn’t have to. Thought about what would happen if he accumulated enough sand in his heart. Would his heart stop, would a hole form, from the knocking around of each grain.

His mind drifted out and away from the bonfire and the sand toward the waves. He remembered seeing a man and his daughter or maybe it was his granddaughter, of about 5 or 6 years, thigh-deep in the water in California. He was holding her by her hands as the waves came in. It was close to sunset. They were facing the other way, facing the Pacific. He sat there, Francois did. He sat down in his apartment and thought of them, just as he sat on the rocks at that beach. The weight of what the father or grandfather must have dealt with over the course of his life and what he must have been worried or stressed about in that present moment. Yet he was shelving all of that, his past and present, to spend time with his daughter or granddaughter. To hold her up, and play in the sunset. Francois smiled. He thought for a second and realized he couldn’t remember many other sunsets from his life. A few, but not many. The father-figure would probably go on to enshrine that memory for the rest of his life. But what about the daughter? Would she remember in 10, 15, 20? Minutes, hours, years? Something climbed up and out him, out of his stomach and throat and mouth. It wasn’t vomit, wasn’t a frog in his throat, and wasn’t a yawn or burp. It was something like a laugh or happiness. Because something clicked again. It didn’t matter if the daughter-figure remembered or forgot instantly, because he knew that there were moments like that one in him that he’d forgotten, just like she might forget and just like the sunsets of his own he’d left behind. Every person contains some proportion of this raw material of love. Foundational moments that silently keep someone afloat in dark times. The ones who say they have had none, carry no moments such as the girl’s? “If they truly don’t, if that’s even possible,” Francois thought. “If they have none, then it is even more important to be kind to strangers, for any one of them could be unravelled by us, ourselves, and we... in the present.” Francois felt his way through the question even more, followed his sandy heart and decided that no one, not a single person, could stay in this world without some kindness-core within them, keeping them going. Even an orphan forms bonds, makes connections, survives. Francois didn’t know any orphans, but felt in his bones that an orphan must have memories—whether of the orphanage staff or peers—that keep them moving forward. Moments of tenderness between the orphan and a friend, or between the orphan and the kind-hearted staff member who gave her her first grapefruit in the dead of night. A bittersweet brightness in the dark. Juice stains on the orphan’s clothes and a few that bit into the floorboards beneath the bed. “Does grapefruit stain?” Francois wondered.

Something tugged at Francois on this thought. *They* weren’t enjoying this musing and wanted him to focus. He turned in his seat, wondering if the

kodama were responsible. Leaned, lazily and without getting up, to try to see around a big leaf of his only plant. “Not enough forest there,” he thought. He waited nonetheless. Waited for whatever this spirit was to direct him where he needed to start moving with his train of thought. Slowly, Francois’ brow furrowed with deep grooves. Became aware of the grooves and pictured a small version of himself planting into them, only to unfurrow his brow and complete the burying. His mind drifted back to the fear and emptiness some people felt after a drought. He’d heard that some people felt droughtexit as a relief, a breathing and surfacing from previously not having been able to breathe or surface. Like swimming below the ocean surface for too long and then finally coming up and breathing the air again. His experience of the droughts was different. They always felt like a mirage that culminated in reaching it, after having walked towards it for miles, and realizing that finally touching the mirage dispelled it. Woke him up in his bed at home. The memories that greeted him on this last waking warmed him up in his cold apartment. Something in him intuited that very few people of his ilk experienced droughts the same way. He turned his attention to the idea of the communal disorientation and amnesia he’d been told of: beneath the superficial homogeneity, he discerned something else at play. Maybe difference, but—ultimately—he didn’t know. Speculation was just that, anyway.

This last drought, his mom came to save him from his crying. She knew, somehow, that he was in trouble. And drove to help. He had no clue how driving could possibly work during a drought, but she did it. He liked to call her MoMA (and named other family members after museums, too). Because they were all pieces of work. Of art too, of course—but work nonetheless. The driving there, though. “SuperMoMA,” he suggested to himself. It didn’t quite flow as nicely as plain MoMA but made him smirk. Just a little. What he found even weirder about the whole thing, was that his mom managed to get him into a car and to a hospital. He usually refused any car usage during a drought, but she got him in one. Something in Francois tightened up, grew taut. He remembered what he’d set out to remember. (Kodama can lead a human to water, but can’t make them remember.)

His mom was at his door, knocking in a pattern he didn’t recognize. She told him to come out to the car and go to the hospital with her. He refused. She persuaded. He said, “Fine but we need to take my car and I’m not driving.” Mutual assent and a gathering of his things. What he was going for, he didn’t know, but she seemed to know and that comforted him. And then suddenly he found himself reaching for the door handle of his car on the passenger side and, in his periphery, could see his mother doing the same for the driver side door. As he sat in the passenger seat and saw his mom getting ready to drive his car, he had his realization: she will not be here forever and one day she won’t be able to drive him to a hospital to get help. He couldn’t help it. Part of him scoffed at those people who claim not to have a kindness-core keeping them going. You can find a kindness-core at any time, at any moment in your life. In the smallest of moments, in the worst. But always just around the corner. Waiting for you

and waiting for you to comprehend the raw material of what can only be called love. For no other word fits. Containing love in one place, in four letters, felt like putting God in a thimble. He laughed and wondered if his relationship with the droughts was so positive and free of pain because he carried many kindness-cores in him. If those who carry no kindness are deserving of kindness, what does it mean to carry too many, too much? Does he deserve the trials of a rich man. Is he worth less for having more of worth.

Then the shouting, the screaming. He was dizzy and his mom was driving. They were on their way to the hospital. The sand in his heart was killing him.